

2022

BROWNIE IN REVIEW



Brownies were these one dollar, bite-sized cameras. Arguably the fast-food of cameras. Why are they special? Because anything can be perceived as special if it can trigger a certain depth of thought, or feeling in you. And these brownies did bring that about it me, neither thought nor feeling, but an deep capacity to vessel a narrative.

If there's a thrilling chemistry between the writer, and what's weaving in his head, if the tension between having an instinct and executing it is nourishing - reading such work, brings a vigour to the voice in my head. I believe, this is what Brownies brought to photography. A sense of ease in an intense activity. There's an ironical story of a British soldier who clicked a great variety of pictures of the war, but never got to see them, because he lost sight soon after.

I wonder if he does really mind it though. I wonder if his memory of the war is more vivid than ever. Not vivid in imagery, because you tend to lose memory with age. But vivid in the feelings it storms up in the floor of his gut. Isn't that what pictures do anyway though - hold a mirror to a memory.

Brownies, now, to me, look like the Instagram of the 20th century. A revolution of convenience, spun upon on photographs, and wide-scale profits. It'd be interesting to study the market shifts it brought about. If I do study them, I'd be careful to consider those only as a reflection of the times and not necessarily the people. Maybe because, if the future generations were to gauge our zeitgeist I'd like them to separate what is portrayed on Instagram from what we carried.



"All photographs are memento mori. To take a photograph is to participate in another person's (or thing's) mortality, vulnerability, mutability. Precisely by slicing out this moment and freezing it, all photographs testify to time's relentless melt."

- Sontag

